ROAMI TRAVEL

China Starter Kit

Your Pre-Trip Setup Guide

"China is amazing. Traveling here shouldn't be hard."

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China Starter Kit — Your Pre-Trip Setup Guide

Welcome

If you're reading this, you're probably planning your first or second trip to China — and you've just discovered that almost nothing from back home works here. No Google Maps. No Uber. Even WhatsApp is blocked.

Don't panic. This guide will get you set up in one evening. Everything here is tested and current as of October 2026. Follow the steps in order, and by tomorrow you'll be ready to land, pay for things, find your way around, and actually enjoy the trip instead of fighting with apps.

This is the free starter guide from Roami Travel. If you find it useful, our **Shenzhen Playbook** ($19) takes the next step: 60+ locally researched spots with exact Chinese addresses, one-tap navigation, and ready-to-walk routes.

Let's get you ready.

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1. Quick Start — The 10-Minute Pre-Departure Checklist

Complete these tonight, before you leave for the airport:

- ☐ **Download Alipay** and complete identity verification (passport photo + selfie)
- ☐ **Download WeChat** and set up an account
- ☐ **Link your international card** to Alipay (Visa/Mastercard/Amex/JCB)
- ☐ **Buy and install an eSIM** (Airalo, Holafly, Nomad, or RedteaGo)
- ☐ **Download Amap** (高德地图) for navigation
- ☐ **Download DiDi** for ride-hailing
- ☐ **Notify your bank** that you'll be traveling in China
- ☐ **Screenshot your hotel address** in Chinese characters (show to taxi drivers)
- ☐ **Fill out the electronic arrival card** online at s.nia.gov.cn (optional but saves time)

If you complete these steps, you'll land ready to pay, navigate, and get online within minutes. Everything else can wait.

Last verified: 2026-10-12

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2. Visa, Entry & Arrival Card

Do You Need a Visa?

China's visa policy has expanded significantly. As of 2026, three main pathways allow visa-free entry:

1. 30-Day Visa-Free Entry (50 countries) China offers 30-day visa-free entry for ordinary passport holders from 50 countries, including:

- **Europe (35):** France, Germany, Italy, Netherlands, Spain, Switzerland, Ireland, Hungary, Austria, Belgium, Luxembourg, Poland, Slovenia, Portugal, Greece, Cyprus, Slovakia, Norway, Finland, Denmark, Iceland, Andorra, Monaco, Liechtenstein, Bulgaria, Romania, Croatia, Montenegro, North Macedonia, Malta, Estonia, Latvia, Russia, Sweden, UK
- **Oceania (2):** Australia, New Zealand
- **Asia (7):** Brunei, South Korea, Japan, Saudi Arabia, Oman, Kuwait, Bahrain
- **Americas (6):** Brazil, Argentina, Chile, Peru, Uruguay, Canada

Important: The United States is **not** on this list. Most policies are valid through December 31, 2026 (Brunei has no end date; Russia through December 31, 2027).

2. 240-Hour Transit Visa-Free (57 countries) If you're transiting through China to a third country or region, you can stay up to 240 hours (10 days) visa-free. You must hold confirmed onward tickets to a destination other than your country of origin. This covers 57 nationalities and 65 ports of entry.

3. Traditional Visa If you don't qualify for visa-free entry, apply for a visa at a Chinese embassy or consulate. Processing typically takes 4-7 business days.

Electronic Arrival Card

Since November 20, 2025, you can pre-fill your arrival card online before entering China. This saves time at the border.

How to fill it out:

1. Visit the National Immigration Administration portal: s.nia.gov.cn
2. Or use the "移民局12367" app (search in your app store)
3. Or scan the QR code at your departure airport
4. Fill in your passport details, flight information, and accommodation address
5. Save the confirmation — you'll show it to immigration on arrival

No fee is charged for this service. You can also fill out the paper card on the plane if you prefer.

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3. Payments — Alipay, WeChat Pay & Alternatives

The Payment Landscape

China runs on mobile payments, but it's not a cashless monopoly. Three channels coexist:

- **Mobile payments dominate** — Alipay and WeChat Pay are the default for most transactions
- **Cash remains legal tender** — businesses cannot refuse it, though it's increasingly rare in cities
- **International cards work in limited scenarios** — hotels, upscale restaurants, and some retail chains accept Visa/Mastercard, but most small vendors don't have card terminals

You need at least **one** mobile payment app set up before you land.

Alipay (Recommended for Foreigners)

Alipay is the easiest option for international visitors. It accepts foreign cards and has an English interface.

Setup steps:

1. Download Alipay from your app store
2. Sign up with your international phone number (include country code, e.g., +1 for US)
3. Verify your identity: Tap "Me" → your profile → "Real-name verification" → photograph your passport and take a selfie (processing: minutes to 24 hours)
4. Add your card: "Me" → "Bank Cards" → "Add Card" → enter Visa/Mastercard/Amex/JCB details
5. Set a 6-digit payment password
6. Test with a small purchase (convenience store, coffee)

Fees: Single transactions under ¥200 are free. Transactions over ¥200 incur a 3% international card processing fee.

Troubleshooting: If your card is declined, try Alipay's "TourCard" feature (search "TourCard" in the app) — it's a prepaid top-up balance that bypasses some card-issuer blocks. Availability varies; check the app for current options.

WeChat Pay

WeChat Pay is nearly as universal as Alipay but slightly harder for foreigners to set up.

Setup steps:

1. Download WeChat (微信, Wēixìn)
2. Sign up with your phone number
3. Enable WeChat Pay: "Me" → "Services" → "Wallet"
4. Add your international card: "Cards" → "Add a card"
5. Complete identity verification if prompted

Fees & waiver (APEC 2026 announcement):

- **First-time users:** Link an international bank card and enjoy a **90-day fee waiver** (up to ¥1,000 in daily transactions). This promotional period runs through December 31, 2026.
- **All transactions:** Single transactions ⩽ ¥200 are always fee-free, regardless of the waiver.

- **After waiver or over ¥200:** A 3% international card processing fee applies.

Monthly spending limits depend on your verification level and card issuer. With full identity verification, daily limits are generally sufficient for travel.

Alternative: PayPal World (US Users)

If you're a US PayPal user, you can now pay at WeChat Pay merchants by scanning their QR codes with the PayPal app (launched August 2026). No Chinese bank account or WeChat installation required. Currently available to US accounts only.

Alternative: UnionPay Nihao China App

UnionPay's "Nihao China" app (launched December 2025) provides a one-stop payment and travel wallet for visitors. It accepts international cards (UnionPay, Visa, Mastercard, JCB, Diners Club) for QR-code payments across China and includes transit coverage in 43 cities. No Chinese phone number required — register with your overseas phone number or email. Check the app for current features and supported services.

Pro Tips

- **Set up both Alipay and WeChat Pay** before departure. Alipay is more reliable with foreign cards; WeChat Pay is accepted at more small vendors. Between the two, you'll cover nearly all situations.
- **Keep your payment code live** — don't screenshot or save it. Open the app fresh each time you pay. If the code fails to load, use the backup method (switch apps or use cash).
- **Notify your bank** before the trip. Many card declines happen because the bank flags China transactions as suspicious.
- **Always carry ¥200-500 in cash as backup.** Some places (old markets, rural areas) still prefer cash, and it's your fallback when apps fail.

Common Pitfalls

- ☒ Assuming your card will work at a terminal — most restaurants and shops have **no card terminals**. Mobile payment is the default.
- ☒ Setting up only after landing — airport Wi-Fi is unreliable and you need payments to take a DiDi from the airport.
- ☒ Forgetting your payment password — resetting it requires identity re-verification, which can take 24+ hours.
- ☒ Not realizing WeChat and WhatsApp are completely different apps. WhatsApp is blocked in China.

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4. Internet & eSIM

What You Need

Many Western apps are blocked or throttled in China: Google, WhatsApp, Instagram, Facebook, YouTube, Twitter/X, and most news sites. You need reliable internet with a workaround.

Your options, ranked by convenience:

Option	Pros	Cons
Travel eSIM (recommended)	Works on arrival, includes roaming data that routes around the firewall	More expensive than local SIM
Local SIM card	Cheap, fast local data	Requires passport registration; some apps still blocked
Phone roaming from home	Simplest setup	Expensive; depends on carrier

Travel eSIM (Recommended)

1. **Buy before departure**: Popular providers include Airalo, Holafly, Nomad, and RedteaGo. Search "[China] eSIM" in their apps.
2. **Choose a plan**: For a 5-7 day Shenzhen trip, 3-5 GB is usually enough (maps, messaging, occasional browsing).
3. **Install before departure**: Scan the QR code or follow in-app instructions. The eSIM profile installs but doesn't activate until you land.
4. **Enable data roaming** when you land: Settings → Cellular → [your eSIM] → turn on Data Roaming.
5. **Test immediately**: Open a browser and try loading Google. If it works, your eSIM is routing international traffic correctly.

eSIM Compatibility

For foreign-issued travel eSIMs (Airalo, Holafly, Nomad, etc.), your phone must support eSIM. Most phones sold outside mainland China since 2020 do. Check your phone model if unsure.

For mainland China eSIMs (if you want a local Chinese carrier plan): Only specific iPhone models support eSIM in mainland China — **iPhone 18 Pro, iPhone 18 Pro Max, iPhone Duo, iPhone 17e, and iPhone Air**. You must activate eSIM in person at a China Mobile, China Telecom, or China Unicom retail store with a government-issued ID. Most older iPhones sold in China (including iPhone 17 Pro/Pro Max) do NOT support eSIM. For short-term visitors, foreign-issued travel eSIMs remain the practical choice.

Pro Tips

- **Buy an eSIM that covers "Asia" or "China" specifically** — global plans sometimes don't include mainland China.
- **Keep your home SIM active** for receiving SMS verification codes (banks, apps). Turn off data roaming on your home SIM to avoid surprise charges.

- **Download offline content before departure**: Google Maps offline packs, translation dictionaries, and your Roami Playbook PDF all work without internet.
- **Dual-SIM phones**: If your phone supports eSIM + physical SIM, consider getting a Chinese data SIM at the airport (China Unicom counter, ~¥100-150 for 30 days of data) as a cheaper backup.

Common Pitfalls

- ☒ Relying on airport Wi-Fi — it's spotty and won't help you navigate from the airport.
- ☒ Assuming a VPN app will work — many are blocked. eSIMs with international routing are more reliable.
- ☒ Forgetting to enable data roaming after landing — the eSIM is installed but dormant until you toggle it on.

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5. Maps, DiDi & Metro

Maps & Navigation

Google Maps does **not** work reliably in China. The maps are often outdated, and navigation features are disabled. You need a local alternative.

Primary: Amap (高德地图)

1. Download Amap before departure
2. Switch to English: Profile (bottom right) → Settings (gear icon) → Language → English *(Note: English support is improving but still incomplete; some menus and POI names may remain in Chinese)*
3. Search by Chinese name: Copy-paste the Chinese name from your Roami Playbook. English search works for major landmarks but fails for restaurants and smaller venues.
4. Navigate: Tap the location → "Navigate" (导航) → choose driving/walking/transit
5. Show taxi driver: If taking a taxi, tap the location → "Share" → copy the link, or simply show the driver your phone screen with the Chinese name and map pin

iPhone users: Apple Maps in China uses Amap data and supports English natively. It's a good fallback if you don't want to learn Amap's interface.

DiDi (Ride-Hailing)

DiDi (滴滴) is China's ride-hailing app.

1. Download DiDi: Search "DiDi" in your app store. The English version is called "DiDi - Greater China" or just "DiDi."
2. Sign up with your phone number (international numbers work)
3. Link payment: Add your Alipay or international card in the payment settings
4. Set your pickup location: DiDi uses your GPS automatically. Verify the pin on the map — GPS can drift 50-100 meters in dense areas.
5. Enter destination: Paste the Chinese name from your Playbook
6. Choose ride type:

- **Express (快车)** — standard, cheapest
- **Premier (专车)** — nicer car, ~30% more
- **Taxi (出租车)** — hails a regular taxi

1. Confirm and ride: The app shows driver details, car model, plate number, and ETA

Show Driver feature: In your Roami Playbook, each POI has a "Show Driver" button that displays the destination in large Chinese characters. Hand your phone to the driver — no talking required.

Metro (Subway)

Metro is faster than DiDi during rush hour and covers most tourist areas.

Payment options (in order of convenience):

1. **Contactless international bank card (recommended for Shenzhen):** Tap your Visa, Mastercard, American Express, JCB, or UnionPay card directly on the gate reader. Available across all 17 lines and 432 stations since September 10, 2026. Make sure your card has contactless payment enabled. **Use the same card to enter and exit.** No cash or local transit card needed.
2. **Alipay transit code:** Open Alipay → tap "Transport" (出行) on the home screen → switch the city to your location → a metro QR code appears; scan it at the gate to enter and exit. Works with your linked international card.
3. **Single-journey tokens:** Available at station machines (coin/¥5/¥10/¥20 bills accepted; no ¥50/¥100).

Metro tips:

- Metro navigation: Amap shows metro routes, transfers, and exit numbers. This is crucial — the wrong exit can add 10 minutes of walking.
- Airport to city: Shenzhen Bao'an Airport → Futian by metro (Line 11) takes ~35 minutes and costs ¥7. Much cheaper than a DiDi (¥80-120).

Common Pitfalls

- ☒ Relying on Google Maps — it will show you lost or send you to outdated locations.
- ☒ Searching in English only — most small restaurants and shops have no English listing on any Chinese map app.
- ☒ Ignoring metro exit letters — "Exit A" and "Exit B" can be on opposite sides of a major intersection.
- ☒ Trying to hail a taxi on the street — almost impossible. Use DiDi.
- ☒ Not checking the plate number — make sure the car that pulls up matches the app display.
- ☒ Expecting drivers to speak English — they almost never do. Use the "Show Driver" screen or have the Chinese address ready.

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6. Trains & Intercity Travel

China's high-speed rail network is world-class. For intercity travel (e.g., Shenzhen → Guangzhou in 30 min, or Shenzhen → Shanghai in 7 hours), you need to book tickets.

Option	Best For
Trip.com (international)	English interface, foreign card, easy refunds
12306 app (official)	Official English interface; cheapest and most direct

Booking via Trip.com

1. Download Trip.com or visit trip.com
2. Search trains: Enter departure city, arrival city, date
3. Select your train: Second class (二等座) is fine for most routes. First class (一等座) offers more space. Business class (商务座) is luxury.
4. Enter passenger details: Passport number, name (as it appears on passport)
5. Pay: International cards work on Trip.com
6. Collect your ticket: China rail uses e-tickets linked to your passport

Note: Trip.com and similar third-party platforms charge a service fee (amount shown on order page). The official 12306 platform has no platform fee.

Using 12306 (Official Platform)

1. Download "铁路12306" from the app store
2. Switch to English & register: The 12306 app and website (12306.cn/en) offer an official English interface. Register with your email and passport scan, complete real-name verification
3. Search, select, pay: Same flow as Trip.com. Alipay works for payment.

Important for foreign passport holders:

- You can buy tickets online via 12306, but you must pass through **manual ID-check lanes** at stations (auto-gates don't read foreign passports)
- Always carry the passport you used to purchase the ticket
- For popular routes, book 10-15 days ahead (holidays, weekends sell out fast)

Beijing-Shanghai advance booking pilot: Since July 20, 2026, Beijing-Shanghai trains (both high-speed and conventional) allow advance booking up to 60 days before departure via the 12306 app "预约购票" section.

Pro Tips

- **Arrive 30+ minutes early** — security checks at train stations are like airports
- **Bring your passport** — you need it to enter the station and board the train
- **Shenzhen has multiple stations:** Shenzhen North (深圳北) for most high-speed trains, Shenzhen Station (深圳站) for some Guangzhou routes, Futian Station (福田站) for cross-border HK trains

Common Pitfalls

- ☒ Showing up without your passport — you cannot board
- ☒ Confusing Shenzhen stations — "Shenzhen" and "Shenzhen North" are 30+ minutes apart by metro
- ☒ Booking too late on holidays — Chinese New Year, National Day (Oct 1-7), and Labor Day (May 1-5) sell out within minutes

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7. Restaurant Ordering & Translation

Restaurant Ordering

Most restaurants in China don't have English menus. Many use QR code ordering (scan the table QR → order on your phone → pay on your phone).

Step-by-step:

1. Sit down — a host may direct you, or you grab an open seat
2. Scan the QR code on the table (use WeChat or Alipay scanner)
3. Browse the menu — it opens a mini-program with photos, prices, and descriptions (in Chinese)
4. Use image translation: Screenshot the menu → open your translation app → translate the image
5. Add items to cart → submit order. The kitchen gets it instantly
6. Pay in the same app — Alipay or WeChat Pay

If QR ordering fails: Some restaurants have paper menus or wall photos. Point at what you want. You can also show the waiter your translation app with key phrases.

Translation Tools

Tool	Best For
DeepL (app or web)	High-quality translation for Chinese ↔ English
Baidu Translate (百度翻译)	Offline mode, camera translation, Chinese-optimized
WeChat Translate	Quick in-chat translation (long-press message → translate)
Google Translate (offline pack)	Pre-download Chinese offline pack before departure

Camera translation:

1. Open your translation app (Baidu Translate or Google Translate)
2. Select "Camera" mode
3. Point at Chinese text (menu, sign, label)
4. The app overlays English translation in real time

Pro tips:

- Download offline language packs before departure — you won't always have data
- Photo menus are common: Many restaurants display large photo menus on the wall
- Dianping (大众点评) is China's Yelp — it has photos and reviews but is in Chinese. Useful for finding popular dishes at a restaurant

Common Pitfalls

- ☒ Waving for a waiter — in QR-ordering restaurants, there's no waiter to wave at. Look for the QR code.
- ☒ Ordering random things — use photo translation or ask your Roami Concierge before ordering

- ☒ Forgetting to specify "no spice" (不要辣, *bù yào là*) — Sichuan and Hunan cuisines are extremely spicy by default
- ☒ Relying on voice translation in noisy environments — use text input instead
- ☒ Trusting machine translation blindly — some idioms and food names translate poorly. When in doubt, show the original Chinese text to a local

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8. Hotel & Accommodation Registration

Hotels

Most hotels in China can accommodate foreign guests. By national policy (since May 2024), no hotel may refuse you solely for lacking a "foreign guest license" (涉外资质) — that concept has been abolished. If refused, cite the public security ministry directive.

In practice: Some budget hotels still turn foreigners away due to unfamiliarity with registration procedures. Patience and persistence help. When booking, confirm the hotel can register foreign guests.

Registration process: Hotels are required to register foreign guests with local police within 24 hours of check-in. The hotel handles this automatically — you just need to provide your passport.

Non-Hotel Accommodation (Airbnb, Friends' Apartments)

If you're staying outside a hotel (e.g., Airbnb, friend's apartment), **you or your host must register with police within 24 hours.**

Since September 21, 2026, this can be done online:

- Visit the NIA website or use the "移民局12367" app
- Or use WeChat/Alipay mini-programs (search "移民局12367")
- Either you or your host can complete the registration (first time: host should do it; subsequent registrations at the same address: you can do it yourself)
- Online and in-person registrations have equal legal effect

If you miss the 24-hour window: You may face a warning or small fine. Register as soon as you realize the gap.

Support hotline: 12367 (NIA service line, English available)

Common Pitfalls

- ☒ Assuming all hotels accept foreigners — confirm before booking
- ☒ Forgetting to register if staying in a non-hotel — the 24-hour rule is strict
- ☒ Not knowing about the online registration option — no need to visit a police station in person

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9. When Things Go Wrong

Emergency Numbers

- **110** — Police
- **120** — Ambulance
- **119** — Fire
- **12367** — National Immigration Administration (visa/entry issues, English available)

Payment Failures

Problem: Your Alipay or WeChat Pay code won't scan or shows "transaction failed."

Solutions:

1. Check your internet connection — switch between Wi-Fi and mobile data
2. Try the other payment app (if Alipay fails, use WeChat Pay)
3. Use cash as backup
4. If your international card is declined, contact your bank (use international roaming to call the number on the back of your card)

Lost or Stolen Phone

Problem: Your phone is lost, stolen, or dead.

Solutions:

1. Use a friend's phone or hotel computer to log into Alipay/WeChat web versions
2. Call your bank to freeze your linked cards
3. Visit a local police station (派出所) to file a report — you'll need this for insurance claims
4. Contact your embassy/consulate if your passport is also lost

Navigation Issues

Problem: You're lost, GPS is inaccurate, or you can't find your destination.

Solutions:

1. Show your Chinese address screenshot to a passerby or shop owner
2. Use DiDi — the driver will navigate for you
3. Find a metro station and use the station map to reorient
4. Ask for help — most Chinese people are willing to help lost tourists, even with language barriers (use your translation app)

Medical Emergencies

Problem: You're sick or injured.

Solutions:

1. Call 120 for an ambulance (serious emergencies)

2. Go to a hospital emergency room (急诊, *jí zhěn*) — major hospitals have some English-speaking staff
3. Use your travel insurance — contact them before treatment if possible
4. Pharmacies (药店, *yào diàn*) can help with minor issues — show symptoms in your translation app

Scams & Safety

Problem: You suspect a scam or feel unsafe.

Solutions:

1. Trust your instincts — if something feels wrong, leave
2. Call 110 if you're in immediate danger or witness a crime
3. Keep copies of your passport and visa separate from the originals
4. Use hotel safes for valuables

Common Pitfalls

- ☒ Panicking when payment fails — there's always a backup (other app or cash)
- ☒ Wandering around lost instead of asking for help — locals are generally helpful
- ☒ Not having emergency numbers saved — screenshot them now

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10. Chinese Phrases & Emergency Numbers

Copy-paste these when you need them. Show your phone screen — no need to pronounce them.

Essentials

English	Chinese	Pinyin	When to use
Hello	你好	nǐ hǎo	Greeting anyone
Thank you	谢谢	xiè xiè	After any service
How much?	多少钱?	duō shǎo qián?	Shopping, ordering
I don't understand	我听不懂	wǒ tīng bù dǒng	When spoken to in Chinese
Do you speak English?	你会说英语吗?	nǐ huì shuō Yīngyǔ ma?	Starting a conversation
I want this	我要这个	wǒ yào zhè ge	Pointing at a menu or item
No spicy	不要辣	bù yào là	Ordering food
Where is the bathroom?	洗手间在哪里?	xǐ shǒu jiān zài nǎ lǐ?	Anywhere
Help!	救命!	jiù mìng!	Emergency only

Getting Around

English	Chinese	Pinyin	When to use
Take me here	带我去这里	dài wǒ qù zhè lǐ	Show address to taxi driver
Stop here	在这里停	zài zhè lǐ tíng	Arriving at destination
Metro station	地铁站	dì tiě zhàn	Asking for directions
Exit	出口	chū kǒu	Finding your way out

Shopping & Dining

English	Chinese	Pinyin	When to use
Too expensive	太贵了	tài guì le	Bargaining
Can it be cheaper?	能便宜点吗?	néng pián yi diǎn ma?	Bargaining
Bill please	买单	mǎi dān	Ready to pay at restaurant
Water	水	shuǐ	Ordering a drink
Beer	啤酒	pí jiǔ	Ordering a drink

Emergency

English	Chinese	Pinyin	When to use
I need help	我需要帮助	wǒ xū yào bāng zhù	General help
I'm lost	我迷路了	wǒ mí lù le	When lost
Hospital	医院	yī yuàn	Medical emergency
I'm allergic to…	我对…过敏	wǒ duì … guò mǐn	Food/medical allergy
My phone is dead	我的手机没电了	wǒ de shǒu jī méi diàn le	Need to charge/borrow phone

Emergency Numbers

- **110** — Police (报警, bào jǐng)
- **120** — Ambulance
- **119** — Fire
- **12367** — Immigration issues (NIA hotline)

11. Roami Shenzhen Sample Card

Here's a taste of what's in the **Shenzhen Playbook** ($19). Each spot includes exact Chinese addresses, metro exits, budget ranges, what to order, and one-tap navigation.

Sample POI: OCT-LOFT Creative Culture Park (华侨城创意文化园)

What it is: A converted industrial area with galleries, cafés, boutiques, and street art. Good for a relaxed afternoon.

Chinese address: 深圳市南山区恩州街 (Show Driver: 带我去华侨城创意文化园)

Metro: Line 1 (Luobao Line) → Qiaocheng East Station (侨城东駅) → **Exit B** → 8-minute walk

Budget: Free to enter; cafés ¥30-60; galleries free

What to do:

- Wander the main paths — street art changes regularly
- Visit the weekend market (Saturday-Sunday) for handmade goods
- Grab coffee at one of the courtyard cafés
- Check out the independent bookshops and design stores

Navigation: Open in Amap *(link opens Amap app if installed)*

Tips:

- Best on weekday afternoons (less crowded)
- Weekend market is worth it but expect crowds
- Several spots accept Alipay/WeChat Pay; a few cafés may have minimum spend for foreign cards

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This is one of 60+ spots in the Shenzhen Playbook. Each entry includes:

- Exact Chinese address and metro exit
- Budget range and what to order
- One-tap navigation buttons
- Foreigner-tested tips (payment, English menu, accessibility)

☒ **Get the Shenzhen Playbook — $19**

China Arrival Cheat Sheet

Single-page, mobile-first reference. Screenshot this page.

Before You Leave Home

- ☐ Download **Alipay** + verify identity (passport + selfie)
- ☐ Link international card (Visa/MC/Amex/JCB)
- ☐ Download **WeChat** + set up account
- ☐ Buy **eSIM** (Airalo/Holafly/Nomad) + install before departure
- ☐ Download **Amap** (高德地图) for navigation
- ☐ Download **DiDi** for ride-hailing
- ☐ Notify your bank of China travel
- ☐ Screenshot hotel address in Chinese
- ☐ Fill electronic arrival card at s.nia.gov.cn (optional)

When You Land

1. **Enable eSIM data roaming** (Settings → Cellular → your eSIM → Data Roaming)
2. **Test internet** — try loading Google
3. **Get through immigration** — show passport + arrival card confirmation
4. **Take DiDi or metro** to your hotel
5. **Test payment** — buy something small with Alipay

Emergency Numbers

- **110** Police
- **120** Ambulance
- **119** Fire
- **12367** Immigration (English available)

Key Apps

App	Purpose
Alipay	Payments
WeChat	Payments + messaging
Amap	Navigation
DiDi	Ride-hailing
Translation app	Camera/text translation

Payment Backup Plan

1. Try Alipay

2. Try WeChat Pay
3. Use cash (carry ¥200-500)
4. International card (hotels/upscale restaurants only)

Metro Payment (Shenzhen)

Fastest: Tap contactless international card on gate reader (Visa/MC/Amex/JCB/UnionPay) — all 432 stations, 17 lines

Backup: Alipay Transit QR code

If You're Stuck

- **Payment fails?** → Try other app, then cash
- **Lost?** → Show Chinese address to passerby, use DiDi
- **Phone dead?** → Use hotel computer, call bank to freeze cards
- **Sick?** → Call 120 or go to hospital emergency room (急诊)

Useful Phrases (Show Your Screen)

- **Take me here:** 带我去这里
- **How much?** 多少钱?
- **No spicy:** 不要辣
- **Bill please:** 买单
- **Help:** 我需要帮助
- **I'm lost:** 我迷路了

You're Ready

If you've worked through this guide, you're prepared for nearly everything China throws at first-time visitors. You can:

- ☒ Pay for things (Alipay + WeChat Pay + cash backup)
- ☒ Get online (eSIM with international routing)
- ☒ Navigate (Amap + Apple Maps)
- ☒ Get around (DiDi + Metro with contactless card)
- ☒ Book trains (Trip.com or 12306)
- ☒ Order food (QR codes + phrases)
- ☒ Translate (camera + voice tools)
- ☒ Handle accommodation registration
- ☒ Know what to do when things go wrong

What's Next?

This kit covers **how to survive in China**. If you're heading to **Shenzhen** and want to know **what to do**, that's where our Shenzhen Playbook comes in.

Shenzhen Playbook — $19

- 60+ locally researched spots with exact Chinese addresses
- 6 ready-to-walk routes (tech, food, culture, city, day trip from HK)
- One-tap navigation buttons — no copy-pasting needed
- Each POI tested: Can you pay with Alipay? Is there an English menu? Which metro exit? What should you order?

☒ **Get the Shenzhen Playbook — $19**

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